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EYE OF THE STORM

1 JUNE 2020

INDIA | 96,990 ACTIVE CASES | 5,626 DEATHS

WORLD | 27,50,337 ACTIVE CASES | 4,19,796 DEATHS

While the country was unlocking itself and economic activity picking up, our scientists were making immense progress as well. The COVID-19 NTF had been working in close contact with various agencies to fill the gaps in production of indigenous medical supplies.

As countries were beginning to cope with the new normal, heartening news was coming in from the global scientific community regarding progress being made in vaccine development. The US, under President Trump's $10-billion fund under Operation Warp Speed, invested about $2.5 billion to help research and develop Moderna's vaccines and buy doses. Pfizer had partnered with BioNTech and produced a working messenger ribonucleic acid (mRNA) vaccine in a record 63 days and had already begun Phase I trials. The UK, on the other hand, in January 2020 had announced the allocation of £40 million in search for a vaccine.

Early last month in May, the prime minister had chaired a meeting with top bureaucrats from concerned ministries, Dr V.K. Paul, Dr VijayRaghavan and officials from the ICMR in which the agenda was to discuss India's vaccination strategy. Dr Bhargava had informed him that the ICMR along with the Department of Biotechnology had successfully isolated a strain of the virus at its Pune-based facility, the NIV. This is one of the foremost critical steps in the road to vaccine development. The prime minister had insisted that India push the model of an 'Entrepreneurial State' even in crafting its vaccine strategy. He had added that the government should look at credible private players as partners in the common goal of making